continues to lag the best global institutions in funding and infrastructure. "Western nations had a considerable head start," she says, pointing to decades of investment in research, infrastructure and institutions. India, she notes, devoted a smaller share of GDP to research and built much of its university system around teaching and not discovery.

Agarwal says younger faculty at IIM-B have considerable academic freedom, lighter teaching loads and gets research grants, international conference funding and research resources. Visiting global scholars give exposure to international research.

Abhay Sobhanan, IIM-B Young Faculty Research Chair in the Decision Sciences Area, studied overseas but says the decision to return was driven largely by the institution and the kind of research he could pursue here. "IIM-B has the institutional quality, colleagues and research support that let me do methodological work without compromise," he says. "And there is a simpler reason too: it is good to be back in your own country."

But it's not just a story of India getting talent. Kedar Nath Thakur, Assistant Professor and Faculty In-charge–MDP and Faculty In-charge–Alumni, MDI Gurgaon, paints a more complex picture. The faculty mix at leading B-schools is changing with scholars trained at Indian institutions increasingly joined by those with international doctorates and teaching experience. Some of the pull is genuine as India offers a fast-changing set of problems to study, he says. Also, stronger rankings and international accreditations have made an Indian faculty position more credible on a CV.

But external factors are playing a role too. In 2025, funding cuts and visa uncertainty in the US unsettled many Indian-origin post-docs and PhD students hoping to build a career there. India may not be pulling that talent back so much as catching it at a point people are reconsidering career plans, says Thakur.

Will these people stay? The answer, says Thakur, may lie in the details of academic life: how quickly research budgets and lab approvals come through, how clear is the tenure and promotion path, and whether the young faculty members have genuine autonomy.

There is another paradox. As Indian B-schools improve their global credentials, their faculty become more visible, intensifying the competition to retain that very talent.

FOREIGN LESSONS



Evolution of B-school Culture: Top Indian IIMs are shifting from traditionally teaching-intensive models to heavy research-driven environments, driving up demand for younger, research-focused faculty



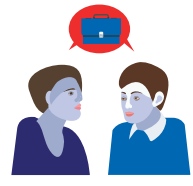
The Brain Circulation Shift: Highly trained academics with overseas PhDs are returning to India not just for personal reasons but also because the country now offers compelling research infrastructure, lighter teaching loads, and institutional support



The Research Advantage: Foreign-trained scholars bring established global networks, exposure to top international practices, and strong publication records that elevate the learning experience for local PhD students and senior faculty alike



India as a Live Business Laboratory: India's rapidly growing consumer market, digital public infrastructure, gig economy, and supply chain dynamics offer unique, high-impact problems for research with global relevance



Structural & Compensation Trade-offs: While public Indian B-schools struggle to match elite Western or private salaries, they offset this with softer lifestyle perks, young faculty chair professorships, flexible research grants, and strong academic autonomy